BEYOND THE SCOREBOARD / THE HEEL PROJECT

AMERICA'S MOST HATED

THE IRON SHEIK

“

The character shows how entertainment can turn a national conflict into a stereotype.

Alex Morgan Hour 5 October 30, 2026

01 The person behind the character

THE WRESTLER

The Iron Sheik

IDENTITY AND PORTRAYAL

The Iron Sheik was played by Hossein Khosrow Vaziri, who was born in Iran. He became especially famous in American wrestling in the early 1980s. His character used Iranian identity and national symbols to make American crowds see him as a threatening opponent.

FIRST IMPRESSIONS

My first idea was that the hostage crisis created the Iron Sheik character. I expected the wrestling story to follow the news almost immediately, but I needed to check when he first used the character.

THE DEFINING DETAIL

The Iranian flag made his national identity visible before the match began. That detail connected a wrestling entrance to an international conflict that many fans already knew from television.

02 The history behind the headline

THE HISTORICAL MOMENT

On November 4, 1979, militants seized the United States embassy in Tehran. Fifty two Americans remained hostages for 444 days, until January 20, 1981. The crisis made relations with Iran a major subject in American news and politics.

THE EVENT

1979-11-04

THE CHARACTER ON RECORD

1972

THE MATCH OR STORYLINE

1984-01-23

WHAT THE TIMELINE ESTABLISHES

The character existed before the hostage crisis. The news could have intensified its meaning for American audiences, but the sequence does not support my original claim that the crisis invented the character. The title match came after the hostages returned.

03 The meaning of the boos

HISTORY IN THE RING

The flag connected the entrance to Iran, while the rivalry with Hulk Hogan gave fans an American hero to support. Hogan defeated the Iron Sheik at Madison Square Garden on January 23, 1984. These choices turned a national contrast into a championship story.

THE AUDIENCE AND ITS FEARS

Many American viewers associated Iran with the hostage crisis. A promoter could use that anger to make an Iranian character an effective villain. The crowd reaction shows that wrestling could borrow existing fears, although a recording alone cannot tell us what every individual fan believed.

WHAT THE PORTRAYAL REVEALS

The character shows how entertainment can turn a national conflict into a stereotype. The portrayal was unfair when it encouraged viewers to treat an entire nationality as an enemy. The difference between a real person and a scripted role matters when judging the story.

A CHANGED UNDERSTANDING

At first I thought the crisis created the character. The earlier character date changed that explanation. My revised argument is that a familiar villain became more useful to promoters after the news gave audiences a new reason to respond to the act.

04 The evidence behind the argument

SOURCE ONE

United States National Archives. Hostage. Archival film about the Iran hostage crisis. https://www.archives.gov/

WHAT THE FIRST SOURCE ESTABLISHES

The archival footage documents the crisis as a real international event. It helps establish historical context. It does not prove that every wrestling fan reacted to the character for exactly the same reason.

SOURCE TWO

WWE. Hulk Hogan versus the Iron Sheik. Madison Square Garden, January 23, 1984. Match recording on the official WWE channel.

WHAT THE SECOND SOURCE ESTABLISHES

The recording shows the presentation of the wrestlers and the response of that crowd. It is a primary source for what the company put in the ring, rather than an independent explanation of American public opinion.

AN INDEPENDENT PERSPECTIVE

The National Archives is outside WWE. Its historical footage can be checked against other records of the hostage crisis. I would still distinguish a film made by a government from a neutral account of every part of the conflict.

THE VISUAL RECORD

I would use a brief part of the official January 23, 1984 match recording, showing the entrance and national symbols. The clip supports my claim about how the company presented the character, rather than proving what all Americans thought.

05 The closing argument

INTRODUCING THE HEEL

The Iron Sheik: the person and the role. Identify Vaziri and Iran, then show the difference between his biography and the wrestling character. Use one entrance image rather than a slide full of text.

CONNECTING THE HEADLINE

Place the character date beside the 1979 crisis and the 1984 title match. Explain why the order changes my claim. The headline gave an existing character a different meaning, rather than creating him.

THE CONCLUSION

My conclusion is that wrestling sold a national conflict through a personal rivalry. The evidence supports a claim about promotion and portrayal. It does not justify treating an entire nationality as a villain.

THE PRESENTATION

Begin with the flag as the opening clue. Identify the person, explain the hostage crisis, then compare the dates. Describe two promotional choices and connect them to the audience. End with my judgment about the stereotype and the limits of my evidence.

DEFENDING THE EVIDENCE

My strongest evidence is the recorded match alongside the verified timeline. The match establishes what was presented, and the dates challenge the idea that the crisis created the act. Neither source can tell me the private beliefs of every person in the arena.

MY FINAL REVIEW

Names, hometown, years, two sentence gimmick: Yes
Historical dates and a checkable fact: Yes
Two specific wrestling details linked to history: Yes
Explain why fans reacted that way then: Yes
Explain whether the character was fair, using facts: Yes
Two trustworthy sources, at least one outside WWE: Yes
Complete your answers: Yes
Historical photo or clip no longer than 30 seconds: Yes
2 to 3 minute delivery, three slides maximum: Yes